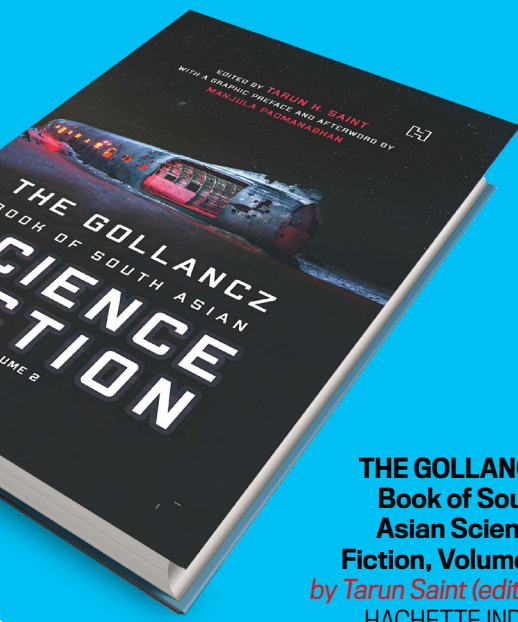
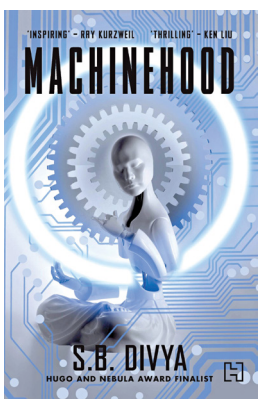


THE GOLLANCZ Book of South Asian Science Fiction, Volume 2
by Tarun Saint (editor)
HACHETTE INDIA,
₹699; 454 pages

things, climate change, religious persecution, the increasing atomisation of our lives amid the galloping ubiquity of surveillance. Strikingly, few of these stories are in any way escapist. They are rooted in the here and now, no matter where the action may be taking place.

This is the great strength of this volume, finally. It sets up its stall in the future, or in a time that isn't our own. But the mirrors it holds up shows us the way things are now, or will very soon be. And it entertains us while doing so. ■

–Avtar Singh



MACHINEHOOD
by S.B. Divya
HACHETTE INDIA
₹499; 416 pages

S.B. Divya's near-future novel about a completely gig-ified economy, locked in debates around the rights of machines, had an eerie and familiar feel: as if we are just two steps away from the ambiguously dystopic world of the novel, and are almost sleepwalking into it. Another excellent science fiction book that sets up grand moral stakes without losing sight of the personal.

UNTIL PROVEN GUILTY

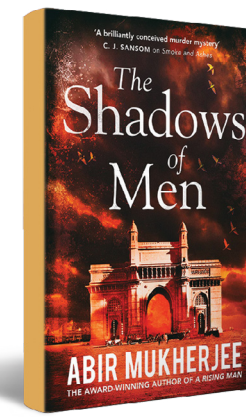
***Abir Mukherjee's** sixth novel in the Wyndham-Banerjee series sees him better already good form*

For those in the thrall of Captain Sam Wyndham and Sergeant Surendranath Banerjee of the colonial Calcutta police, the pair have returned to their familiar milieu, from Lal Bazar (their headquarters) to the backstreets of Calcutta and beyond. This time, however, in a truly ironic twist of fate, Sergeant Banerjee has been falsely accused of committing a murder while on a covert mission for none other than Calcutta's Police Commissioner Lord Taggart. Revealing any more of the events that unfold would result in a spoiler.

Suffice to say that once again Mukherjee's new book is deftly plotted, pays much heed to the prevailing politics of colonial India in the 1940s, and his characters are full-blooded and share many of the beliefs and prejudices of the time. Of course, colonial policing with all its hypocrisy is on full display, the close but nevertheless, inevitably fraught, relationship between Wyndham and Banerjee is adroitly portrayed and British perfidy in promoting and exploiting communal discord carefully woven into the narrative. Mukherjee also demonstrates his knowledge of the nationalist sentiments of the times and deftly uses them as a backdrop for the events in the novel.

This is his sixth novel in the Wyndham-Banerjee series and, arguably, his best since his 2019 thriller, *Smoke and Ashes*, set in Calcutta in the early 1920s. In some of the earlier novels, even as he sketched his two principal protagonists with care, the plots were a bit contrived. For example, in his *A Necessary Evil*, despite a gripping start, the denouement veered into some stereotypical musings about Indian cultural and philosophical beliefs as one of the key characters held forth on both subjects. Consequently, the otherwise fascinating yarn that he had spun tended to unravel at the end.

No such loose ends mark this latest venture. Instead, it is tightly wound, with the narrative smoothly shifting between the two central characters; the reader is treated to insightful interior monologues in every vignette, and past episodes, as necessary, are appropriately recalled. Also, Mukherjee ably shifts locales between Calcutta and Bombay. He is familiar with



THE SHADOWS OF MEN
by Abir Mukherjee
HARVILL SECKER
₹699; 352 pages

the folkways and alleys of both cities, not to mention the social norms of various communities as well as their peculiar prejudices ranging from class to kin.

Without revealing any critical clues, it can be mentioned that the novel has a truly tantalising end. Indeed, the climax is bound to leave every Wyndham-Banerjee aficionado wondering about what will transpire next for this fascinating duo. ■

–Sumit Ganguly